

Example Defect Reports

Worked, high-quality defect reports and what makes them effective.

Why Good Defect Reports Matter

A defect report is only useful if a developer can reproduce and fix the problem without asking you questions. Below are three worked examples of well-written reports. Notice how each one is specific, reproducible, and separates what happened from what should have happened.

Example 1 — Functional Defect

Field	Content
ID	ACME-OLB-DEF-118
Summary	Transfer of exactly £0.00 is accepted instead of being rejected
Environment	Release 2.4 build 812, Chrome 124, test environment
Steps to reproduce	1. Log in as test user. 2. Open "Make a payment". 3. Enter amount 0.00. 4. Select a payee. 5. Click "Send".
Expected result	Validation error: "Amount must be greater than £0.00"
Actual result	Payment is accepted and a £0.00 transaction appears in history
Severity	High
Priority	High

Example 2 — Boundary Defect

Field	Content
ID	ACME-OLB-DEF-124
Summary	Password field accepts 129 characters; limit should be 128
Environment	Release 2.4 build 812, Edge 124, test environment
Steps to reproduce	1. Go to "Change password". 2. Paste a 129-character password. 3. Submit.

Field	Content
Expected result	Rejected with "Password must be 128 characters or fewer"
Actual result	Password is saved; user cannot log in afterwards
Severity	Medium
Priority	High

Example 3 — Usability / UI Defect

Field	Content
ID	ACME-OLB-DEF-131
Summary	Error message overlaps the "Send" button on small screens
Environment	Release 2.4 build 812, Safari 17, viewport 375px wide
Steps to reproduce	1. Open payments on a 375px-wide viewport. 2. Trigger a validation error.
Expected result	Error text sits above the button and both are readable
Actual result	Error text overlaps the button, hiding the label
Severity	Low
Priority	Medium

Severity vs Priority

These are independent. Severity is the impact on the system; priority is how soon it should be fixed. A cosmetic logo error on the home page can be low severity but high priority if it damages the brand before a launch.

- Severity — technical/business impact of the defect.
- Priority — urgency of the fix relative to other work.

What Makes a Good Report

1. A clear, specific summary that reads like a headline.
2. Exact environment and build so it can be reproduced.
3. Numbered, minimal steps to reproduce.
4. Expected and actual results stated separately.
5. Objective severity and priority, plus evidence (screenshot or log).

WHAT MAKES A GOOD REPORT

Write every defect so that a developer who has never seen the feature can reproduce it from your report alone. If you find yourself needing to explain it in person, the written report is not yet complete.

COMMON MISTAKES

Vague summaries ("payment is broken"), missing steps, combining several issues in one report, and mixing up severity and priority. Each of these forces the developer to come back to you and slows the fix.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Always attach evidence. A screenshot, a short recording, or the relevant log line turns a disputed "cannot reproduce" into an accepted, actionable defect — and protects your credibility as a tester.